

Queen's Gambit Declined

The Exchange Variation as a strategic home base

THE PROMISE

Reach the Carlsbad structure deliberately, know both major plans, and meet Black's active deviations without losing the thread.

COURSE VOLUME 02 OF 10

[SEE THE POSITION](#) | [RECALL THE PLAN](#) | [CALCULATE THE MOVE](#)

What this volume should change

- Play the move order 4.cxd5 and 5.Bf4 with a reason for every tempo.
- Choose between the minority attack, central e4 break, and kingside play from concrete cues.
- Meet ...c5, ...Bf5, ...Bb4, ...a6, and unusual recaptures coherently.
- Recognize when Black's activity matters more than the nominal structural target.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	The Exchange Variation spine
02	The minority attack
03	The central e4 break
04	Black strikes with ...c5
05	Black develops ...Bf5
06	Janowski QGD with ...a6
07	Ragozin-style ...Bb4
08	Move-order repairs and rare recaptures

Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

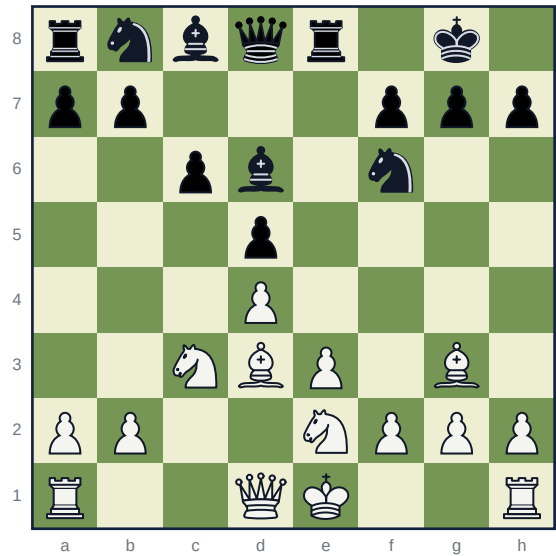
The Exchange Variation spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6: Black has built the classical QGD center.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Exchanging on d5 fixes the Carlsbad structure: White has the c-pawn against Black's e-pawn. Bf4 develops outside the pawn chain before e3 and contests d6. Nge2 keeps the f-pawn free and supports e4. White is not racing to attack; White is arranging a favorable long-term choice between b4-b5 on the queenside and e4 in the center.

White's plan

- Complete Qc2, O-O, and a3 or f3 according to Black's setup.
- Use b4-b5 when Black's c6 pawn is a stable target and the center is controlled.
- Use f3 and e4 when development supports the central break and Black cannot answer with ...c5 effectively.
- Trade Black's active light bishop when doing so improves the relevant plan, not automatically.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Bd6 challenges Bf4 and aims to exchange a useful bishop.
- ...Re8 increases pressure on e3/e4 and prepares central counterplay.
- ...Nbd7-f8-e6 or ...Nf8-g6 improves Black's minor pieces before White breaks through.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Bd6	7.Bg3 keeps the bishop and makes ...Bxg3 open the h-file for White.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Be7	7.Bd3 O-O 8.Nge2; Black has spent no tempo attacking the bishop, so develop.
6...Nbd7	7.Bd3 Be7 8.Nge2 O-O 9.Qc2; preserve the option of e4.
...Nh5	Retreat Bg3 or exchange on d6 according to whether the bishop supports e5 pressure.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Play Bf4 before e3 when legal. If Black's move order creates a tactic on b1-h7 or b4, complete development rather than copying the anchor mechanically.

MEMORY HOOK

Fix with cxd5, develop Bf4, keep e4 alive with Nge2.

CHAPTER 02

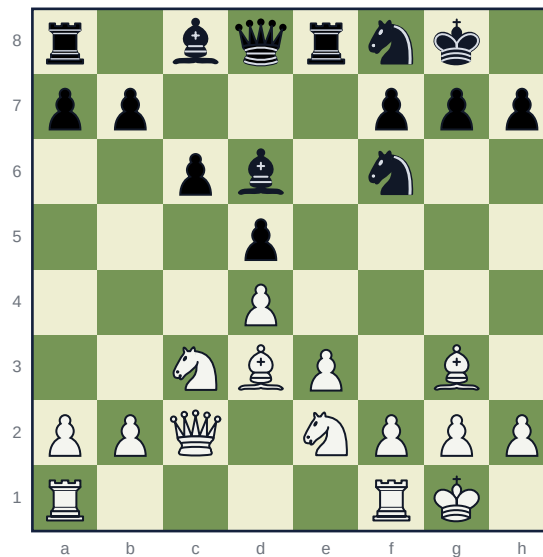
The minority attack

POSITION TRIGGER

The Carlsbad center is stable, Black's c6 pawn is fixed, and ...c5 is not immediately effective.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2 Nbd7 10. Qc2 Nf8 11. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The minority attack uses two pawns against Black's queenside three to create a target. White prepares Rab1 and b4-b5. After ...cxb5, the d5 pawn or backward c6 pawn may become weak; after ...c5, the center changes and White must reassess. The attack is successful when it creates a usable file, square, or pawn target, not merely when b5 appears on the board.

White's plan

- Prepare b4 with Rab1 and a3 when ...Bf5 or ...a5 does not require another move.
- After b5, calculate ...c5 and ...cxb5 first; do not assume Black must wait.
- Place a rook on the b- or c-file and use Na4-c5 or Nc3-a4-c5 when the square is secure.
- Keep enough central control that Black cannot answer a wing attack with ...c5 or ...e5 under ideal conditions.

What Black is trying to do

- ...a5 slows b4 and may seize b4 itself.
- ...b5 closes the queenside but can leave c5 and a5 weak.
- ...c5 liquidates the target and opens play; sometimes it solves Black's problem entirely.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...a5	Use Rab1 and a3, or switch to the center if b4 costs too many tempi.
...b5	Probe the new holes with Na4-c5 and the a-file; do not force a pawn break without entry squares.
...c5	Recalculate the center. dxc5 may isolate d5; preserving tension may keep more pressure.
...Ne4	Exchange or challenge the centralized knight before launching the wing plan.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The minority attack begins only after White is castled and coordinated. Early b4 can hang the pawn to ...a5 or let ...Bf5 win useful tempi.

MEMORY HOOK

Create a target, open a file, occupy the entry square.

CHAPTER 03

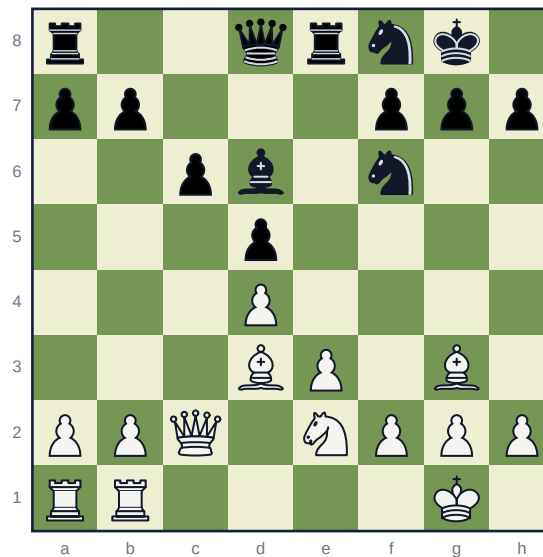
The central e4 break

POSITION TRIGGER

White's pieces support e4, Black's pressure on d4 is controlled, and queenside play would be slow.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2 Nbd7 10. Qc2 Nf8 11. O-O Bg4 12. Rfb1 Bxe2 13. Nxe2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The f3-e4 plan converts White's space and development into a broad center. The move f3 is purposeful but weakening: it takes f3 from the knight, loosens the king, and invites ...c5. Play it only when e4 can follow under favorable circumstances. After e4, White may gain space with e5, exchange to create an isolated d-pawn, or use the open e-file.

White's plan

- Coordinate Qc2, Nge2, and a rook on e1 before breaking if Black controls e4 heavily.
- Calculate ...c5 in response to f3 and e4; Black's best answer is usually central, not passive.
- After e4 dxe4, use fxe4 when it builds a mobile center and the king remains safe.
- If Black blocks with ...dxe4 followed by ...c5, switch from space to development and open-file activity.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks d4 and may exploit the time spent on f3.
- ...Nh5 followed by ...Nxe4 can remove a defender of e4.
- ...Qc7 and ...Be6 add pressure to h2 and control the central break.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...c5 before e4	Decide whether dxc5 leaves Black with an isolated d-pawn or whether e4 can still be forced.
...Nh5	Protect the bishop's purpose; Bg3 is normal, but Bxd6 may remove a key defender.
...b6 and ...Bb7	The bishop increases pressure on d5/e4; complete the break with extra support.
...Qe7	Watch for ...Bxh2+ and tactics on e3 after e4 changes the center.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Nge2 is a repertoire choice because it preserves f3. If you developed Nf3 by another move order, use Ne5, Qc2, and a minority plan more often.

MEMORY HOOK

f3 is a promise: play it only when e4 is coming.

CHAPTER 04

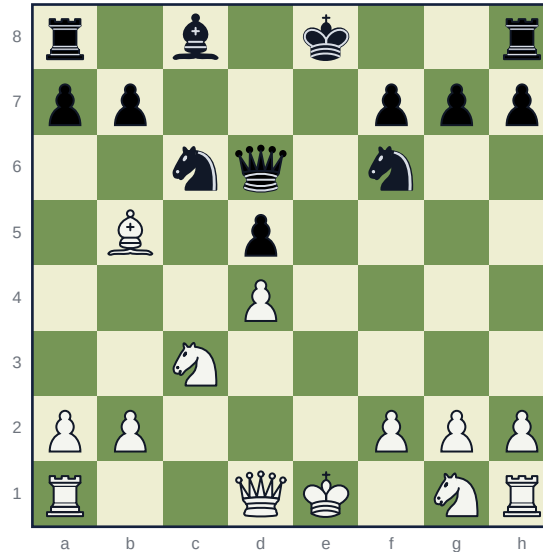
Black strikes with ...c5

POSITION TRIGGER

Black challenges the Carlsbad center before completing the usual ...c6 setup.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c5 6. e3 Nc6 7. Bb5 cxd4 8. exd4 Bd6 9. Bxd6 Qxd6



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The early ...c5 is Black's most direct equalizing idea. White answers by developing with tempo and deciding whether the resulting isolated or hanging pawn structure favors activity. Bb5 increases pressure on c6 and may induce a pin; exd4 is often preferable to Nxd4 because the e-pawn can support a broad center and open the e-file. The position is more dynamic than a quiet minority-attack game.

White's plan

- Use development and pressure on c6/d5 rather than trying to preserve the original structure.
- Castle quickly; open central files increase the value of king safety.
- If Black is left with an isolated d-pawn, blockade d4 and attack it only after neutralizing activity.

What Black is trying to do

- ...cxd4 can give Black free development and an active queen on d6.
- ...Bd6 challenges the strongest bishop and prepares castling.
- ...O-O followed by ...Bg4 or ...Re8 may create initiative before the pawn becomes weak.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...c5	6.e3. Keep development ahead of pawn hunting.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Nc6	7.Bb5 adds pressure; 7.Nf3 is also sound if you prefer simpler development.
7...cxd4	8.exd4 preserves piece activity and an open e-file.
...Bd6	Exchange Bxd6 when it reduces Black's activity without surrendering control of key light squares.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A minority-attack script no longer applies after ...c5 changes the pawn skeleton. Reclassify the position before choosing a plan.

MEMORY HOOK

When ...c5 arrives, stop the wing plan and solve the center.

CHAPTER 05

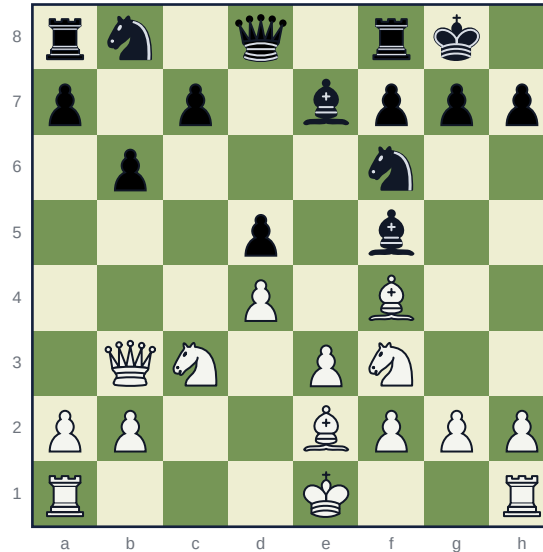
Black develops ...Bf5

POSITION TRIGGER

Black's light bishop reaches f5 before it is enclosed by ...e6 or after the Exchange recapture.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 Bf5 6. Qb3 b6 7. e3 Be7 8. Nf3 O-O 9. Be2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Black solves the traditional bad-bishop problem, so White should not pretend the position is an ideal QGD. Qb3 makes Black account for b7 and d5, often inducing ...b6. White then develops normally and uses the slight queenside dark-square loosening. The knight belongs on f3 here more often because Black's active bishop and faster development make a slow f3-e4 build less attractive.

White's plan

- Use Qb3 to ask a concrete question before Black consolidates.
- Develop Nf3 and Be2; castle before trying to exploit b6 or c7.
- Challenge the bishop with Bd3 if the exchange improves control of e4 and removes activity.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b6 protects b7 and supports ...Bd6 or ...c5, but weakens dark squares.
- ...Nc6 increases d4 pressure and may meet Qxb7 with ...Nb4.
- ...Bd6 offers an equal exchange of active bishops and speeds development.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...Bf5	6.Qb3 asks about b7 and prevents effortless development.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...b6	7.e3; the queen has gained a useful concession, so stop hunting pawns.
6...Nc6	Develop and calculate Qxb7 only if ...Nb4 and ...Rb8 do not trap the queen.
...c5	Treat the position as an active-center branch and prioritize castling.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Qb3 is a pressure move, not a pawn-grabbing license. If taking b7 strands the queen while Black develops with tempo, preserve the positional gain instead.

MEMORY HOOK

Ask b7 one question; accept the concession and develop.

CHAPTER 06

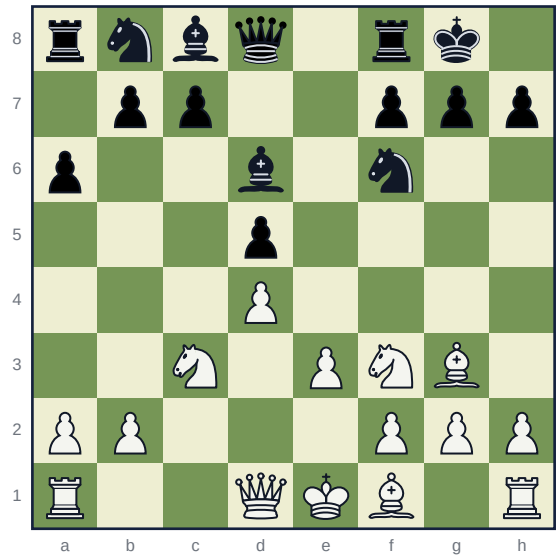
Janowski QGD with ...a6

POSITION TRIGGER

Black inserts ...a6 before ...Nf6 or before committing the queenside knight.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 a6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. Bf4 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. e3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The move ...a6 prepares ...b5 and sometimes ...dxc4 followed by ...b5. White still uses the Exchange structure, but Nf3 is developed before Bf4 to answer ...b5 with a4 or to strike the center with e4 under better control. Black's a-pawn move is useful, yet it is also a tempo not spent on central development. White should open the position only when pieces are ready.

White's plan

- Use the familiar Bf4, e3, Bd3, O-O setup while monitoring ...b5.
- Meet an early ...b5 with a4 when opening the a-file or fixing b5 gives a clear target.
- Consider e4 more readily because ...a6 contributes nothing to central control.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 grabs queenside space and can support ...Bb7.
- ...dxc4 followed by ...b5 may hold the gambit pawn temporarily.
- ...c5 can transpose into an isolated-pawn structure with ...a6 included.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...a6	4.cxd5 keeps the repertoire's structural identity.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...exd5	5.Nf3: control e5 and prepare Bf4 without allowing easy ...b5 tactics.
...b5	Use a4 if it opens a target; otherwise finish development and strike the center.
...dxc4	Recover with Bxc4 after e3 unless tactical calculation supports a stronger central move.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not launch b4 into Black's prepared ...b5 expansion. In this branch, central play often outruns a standard minority attack.

MEMORY HOOK

...a6 spends a wing tempo; answer with development and central readiness.

CHAPTER 07

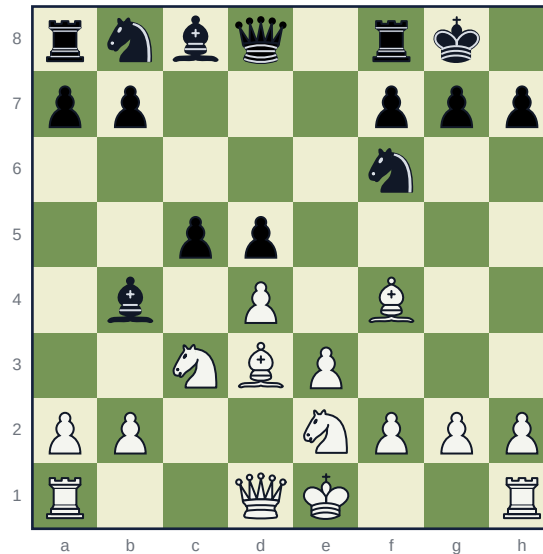
Ragozin-style ...Bb4

POSITION TRIGGER

After the Exchange, Black pins Nc3 with ...Bb4 before White completes development.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 Bb4 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 c5 8. Nge2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The bishop pin increases pressure on c3 and can make e4 tactically premature. White builds with e3, Bd3, and Nge2, ready to castle. If Black exchanges on c3, the b-pawn can recapture and support a strong center; if the bishop retreats, White has gained time. The key is to avoid treating the pin as a positional disaster or breaking the center before the king is safe.

White's plan

- Develop e3 and Bd3 so the king can castle and Bf4 remains supported.
- Recapture bxc3 when it strengthens d4/e4 and the doubled pawn is not an immediate target.
- Use a3 only when asking the bishop a useful question; do not weaken b3 automatically.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks the center while Nc3 is pinned.
- ...Bxc3+ can damage the queenside before White is ready to exploit the bishop pair.
- ...Re8 and ...Nbd7 add pressure to a future e4 break.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...Bb4	6.e3. Build the position and refuse to overreact to the pin.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Bxc3+	Recapture bxc3 when it creates a broad center; use the b-file and bishop pair later.
...c5	8.Nge2 and castle; solve the open center before planning a wing operation.
...Nh5	Protect or exchange Bf4 according to whether e4 or queenside play is the priority.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A pin matters only when the pinned piece must move or a defender is overloaded. Complete development before spending a tempo on a3.

MEMORY HOOK

Pinned knight: build first, break later.

CHAPTER 08

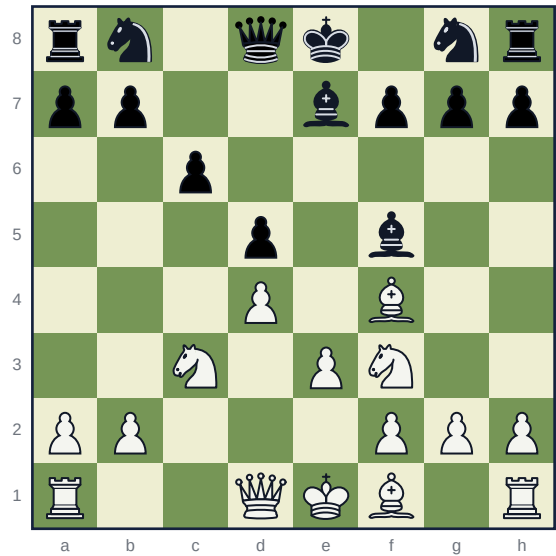
Move-order repairs and rare recaptures

POSITION TRIGGER

Black varies the order with ...Be7, ...Nbd7, ...a6, or an unusual recapture on d5.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Be7 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bf5 7. Nf3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The course's moves are a hierarchy. First create the Exchange structure, then develop Bf4 before e3 when safe, then choose Nge2 or Nf3 based on the plan. If Black recaptures with the knight after an unusual move order, occupy e4 and gain space rather than forcing a Carlsbad structure that no longer exists. When Black delays Nf6, White must respect ...Bf5 and ...c5 as improved resources.

White's plan

- Preserve the structural goal but allow the exact development order to change.
- If ...Bf5 is already active, use Qb3 and Nf3 more often than a slow f3 setup.
- If Black recaptures Nxd5, use e4 to gain space while the knight loses time.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Be7 avoids a tempo on ...Bd6 and keeps options for ...Bf5.
- ...Nbd7 may prepare ...c5 without blocking the f6 knight because it has not moved yet.
- ...Nxd5 can occur only through special move orders and changes the structure completely.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...Be7	4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bf4; keep the core sequence.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...Nbd7	4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bf4; watch ...c5 and ...Bd6.
2...Nf6	3.cxd5 Nxd5 4.e4 gains space and attacks the knight.
...Bf5 before ...c6	Qb3 is the standard question; develop rather than raid b7.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Never memorize a move without its prerequisite. Bf4 requires the diagonal to be safe; Nge2 requires a reason to preserve f3; b4 requires a prepared queenside.

MEMORY HOOK

Keep the hierarchy: structure, development, then plan-specific placement.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Choose the plan

The center is stable and Black has no immediate ...c5. What is White's default queenside operation, and what must be prepared first?



Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2 Nbd7 10. Qc2 Nf8 11. O-O

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Central responsibility

What move is f3 preparing, and which Black counterbreak must be calculated before playing it?



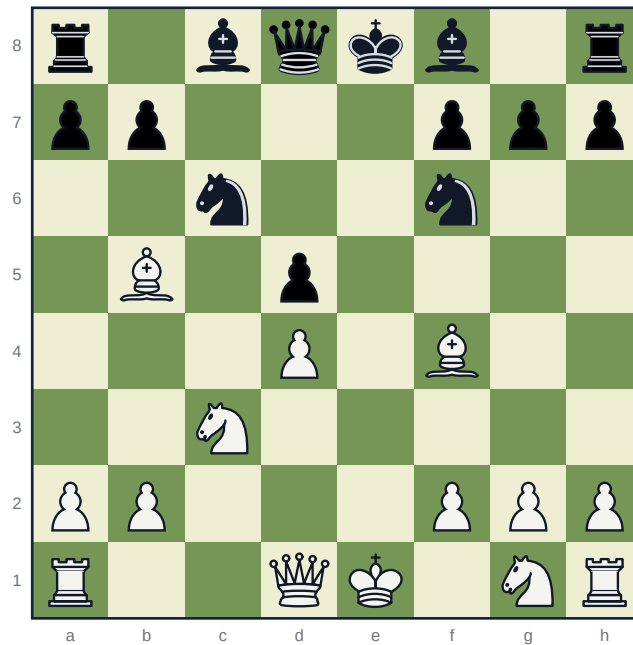
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2 Nbd7 10. Qc2 Nf8 11. f3

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Structure changed

Why is a normal minority-attack plan no longer the right mental model?



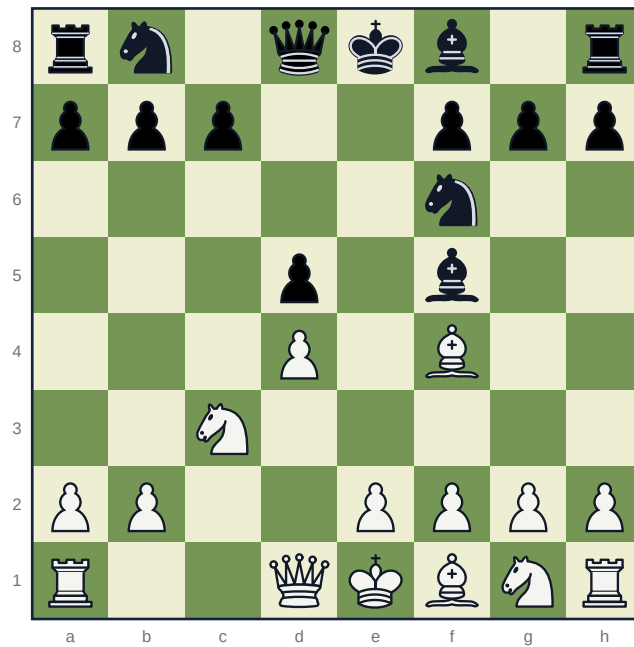
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c5 6. e3 Nc6 7. Bb5 cxd4 8. exd4

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Active bishop

What practical question should White ask immediately, and why is taking b7 not the point?



Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 Bf5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Choose the plan

Prepare the minority attack with Rab1 and a3, then b4-b5. Before committing, calculate ...a5, ...c5, and ...b5. The goal is a target or entry square, not the pawn push itself.

TEST 02 | Central responsibility

White intends e4. The essential reply to calculate is ...c5, either immediately or after e4. If Black can open the center while White is underdeveloped, f3 has created weaknesses without delivering its promise.

TEST 03 | Structure changed

The c-pawns have exchanged and the center is open. White should finish development, use pressure on c6/d5, and evaluate isolated- or hanging-pawn features. The first task is king safety and activity, not b4-b5.

TEST 04 | Active bishop

Play 6.Qb3 to make Black defend b7 and d5. If ...b6 follows, White has induced a structural concession and should develop. A pawn grab that lets Black gain tempi against the queen can erase the positional benefit.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6: Black has built the classical QGD center.	Fix with cxd5, develop Bf4, keep e4 alive with Nge2.
The Carlsbad center is stable, Black's c6 pawn is fixed, and ...c5 is not immediately effective.	Create a target, open a file, occupy the entry square.
White's pieces support e4, Black's pressure on d4 is controlled, and queenside play would be slow.	f3 is a promise: play it only when e4 is coming.
Black challenges the Carlsbad center before completing the usual ...c6 setup.	When ...c5 arrives, stop the wing plan and solve the center.
Black's light bishop reaches f5 before it is enclosed by ...e6 or after the Exchange recapture.	Ask b7 one question; accept the concession and develop.
Black inserts ...a6 before ...Nf6 or before committing the queenside knight.	...a6 spends a wing tempo; answer with development and central readiness.
After the Exchange, Black pins Nc3 with ...Bb4 before White completes development.	Pinned knight: build first, break later.
Black varies the order with ...Be7, ...Nbd7, ...a6, or an unusual recapture on d5.	Keep the hierarchy: structure, development, then plan-specific placement.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.